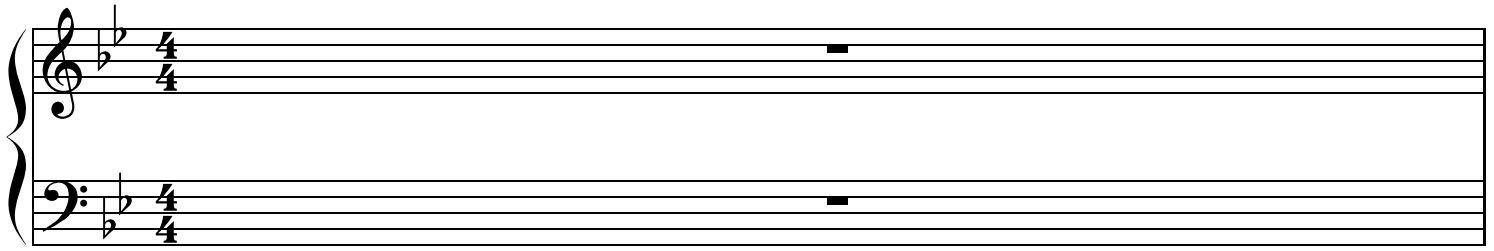


Connor: Barry Harris..."Basics" of Dom 7 Scale (#8)

https://youtu.be/kCSB_iUW5Uk

Transcript: R.Glover 26-Aug-2017

♩=120



Hi everyone. It's Conner again. So, if you watched the previous video about being able to do a scale outline over the 12 bar blues form...[0:10]



...That whole thing, and so on and so forth. Let's say you've mastered that. And then it's like, "Okay, great. I can play a scale outline, but that's not really improvising. What now?" [0:23]

So, let's talk a little bit about what the true meaning of improvisation really is. Okay? [0:32]

The reason why improvisation is, seems to be shrouded in mystery to a lot of people that try to do it or even try to teach it. It's because there's this general assumption that I think is going around that only certain people can do it. That only certain people are hip, good enough to be able to hear what they want to play to make it work over the chord changes. And based on my experiences that's just not true. Because this whole notion of improvisation can really be broken down to a science [1:04]

And I want to tell you historically why that's possible. Okay? If we think about great classical masters and baroque masters of music such as Bach or Mozart or Beethoven and even Liszt and Chopin and a bunch of other people.... they were improvisers too, historically.

Because if you think about it, let's say Mozart is performing a piano concerto that he wrote. And he gets to the end of the third movement, and on his music it says, "cadenza". Which musicians know that means, you know, kind of going off on this grand, kind of like the finale of the piece that you're trying to perform. And, it's common place now for cadenzas, for musicians in recent years, to already be written out. So all the musician has to do is just to read that cadenza. [2:03]

Well, back in those times cadenzas weren't necessarily written out all the time. So, if I'm Mozart and I'm sitting at my piano, and my music says "Cadenza" but I've nothing written there... I have no other choice but to improvise. [2:19]

So what I'm saying here is that even, you know, two hundred, three hundred years ago, the great musicians had to be improvisers in order to successfully play.

You know, we also know historically that someone such as Bach improvised Fugues for royalty on demand. So, why aside from the fact that, you know, Bach and Mozart were musical geniuses, and you could argue they were savants in some way. But other than that, why were they able to improvise like that? And what it really comes down to is because they knew basic things. They knew about scales, and they knew about harmony. [2:58].

So, that's what I'd like to get into today... specifically with the dominant 7th scale. In the previous video, I showed you the scale outline for the 12 bar blues. And because we're primarily dealing with dominant 7th chords of the primary quality of chords that we're trying to improvise over... in that form... that's what I'd like to talk about today. It's just simple ideas on the dominant 7th scale. [3:26]

So, by now you should be able to just run, for instance, a Bb dominant 7th scale by itself.... [3:32].



8 B $\flat$ 7

Musical notation for measure 8, showing a B-flat 7th scale in the treble clef and a whole rest in the bass clef.

[4:53] We can play it, you know, just up and down like that. But what about playing it in thirds?

10

Musical notation for measure 10, showing a B-flat 7th scale in the treble clef and a whole rest in the bass clef.

[5:05] That's one thing we can practice. What about playing it in triads.... [5:10]

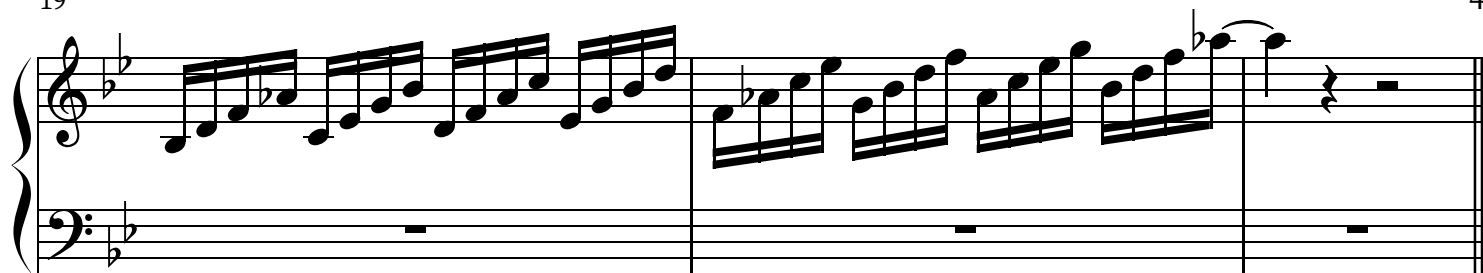
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Musical notation for measure 13, showing a B-flat 7th scale in the treble clef and a whole rest in the bass clef.

You know, just like that. But, today I'd like to take some time to explore what I would consider the basics of, you know, playing small things based upon the scale. Because when we practice small things that come from scales.... what we can do is we can take the small things and we can put them together in an infinite number of different ways. It's almost like speech, you know. You don't learn full sentences at once, especially when you're learning how to speak. You learn about small words, the small phrases first. And then you put them together. It's like me talking to you right now and you know, I'm improvising in a sense because I have an idea of what I'm going to say, but I don't know exactly what I'm going to say. But it's because I've spent, you know, 23, 24 years of my life speaking that it comes naturally to me.

And with improvisation it's the same kind of deal. If you take the time to practice the small things, and then practice putting them together in different ways... then that's the ticket. That's what's really going to accelerate your growth in playing this music.

So, let's talk about a B flat 7th scale. [4:50].

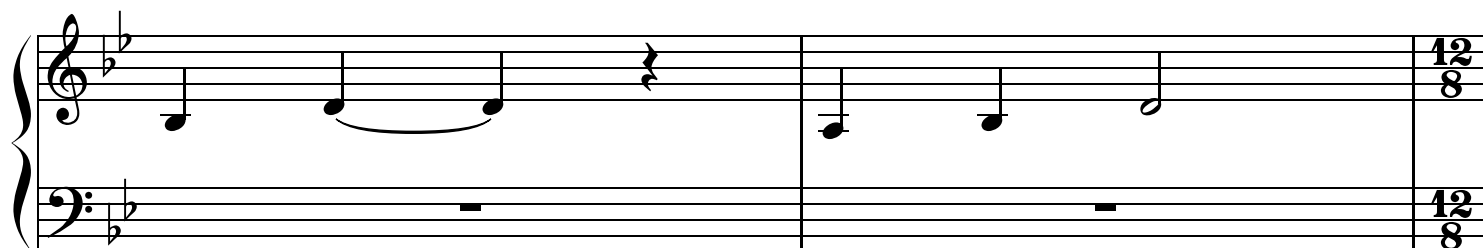


[5:35] That's another tool to utilize. What about if we did those previous three examples, but we added a half step below the first note? So, if I go back to playing thirds for a second.... instead of just playing a third like that I'll approach the first note of the third, a half step below. So, instead of [5:57]

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like that...

I'll do it like this



And I can do that for every single scale degree on the B flat dominant 7 scale. And that looks and sounds like this.... [6:10]

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[6:20] And when you play that at a fast tempo, it sounds pretty impressive...

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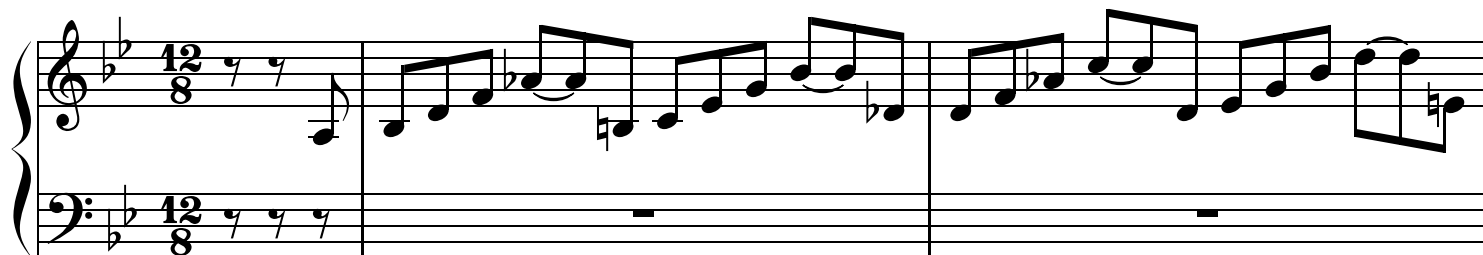


[6:29] Right? What if I did the same thing, but I did triads approaching with the note a half step below....

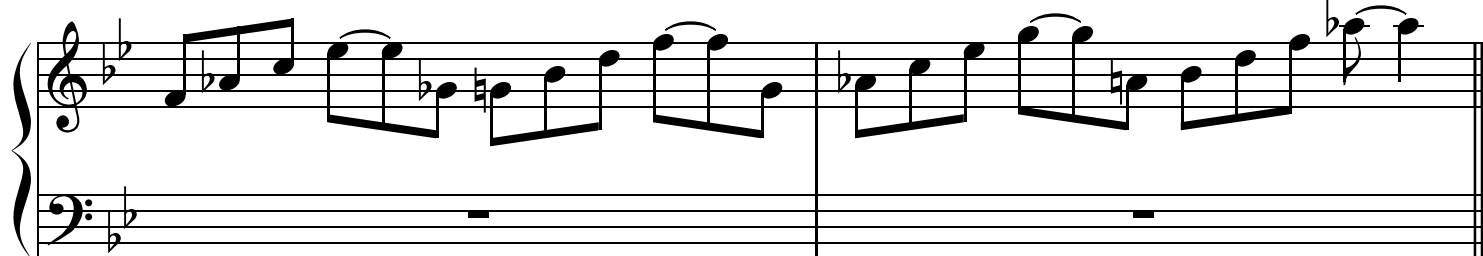


{6:43} What about doing the same thing but with the full 7th chords? ...

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[6:56] Right? So those are some ideas that can intuitively be figured out over any scale, in any key, really. If it works in B flat, on B flat 7, you can bet it's going to work on F sharp 7. You know, if it works on any key, obviously it works in all the other 12 keys.

Let's keep going. What about major arpeggios? And inversions of major arpeggios. So for B flat dominant 7, the important arpeggios are the arpeggios built on scale degree 1, scale degree 5, and scale degree flat 7.

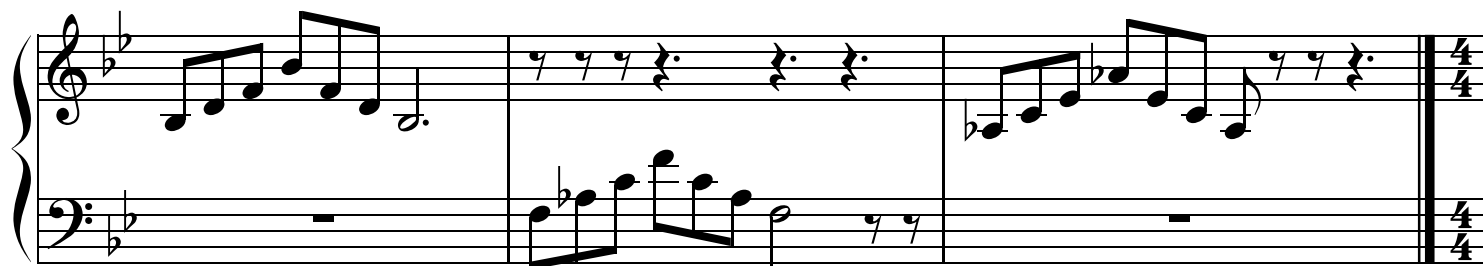
So, in other words, that'll be the B flat major arpeggio, the F minor arpeggio, and the A flat major arpeggio.

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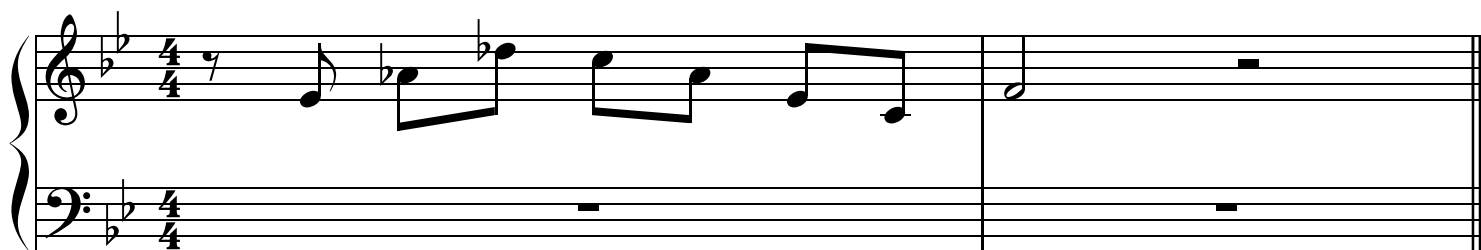
the B $\flat$ major arpeggio

the F minor arpeggio

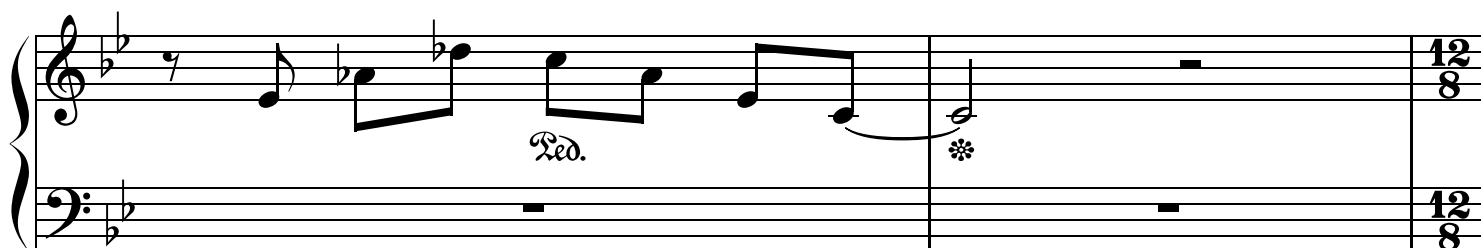
and the A flat major arpeggio



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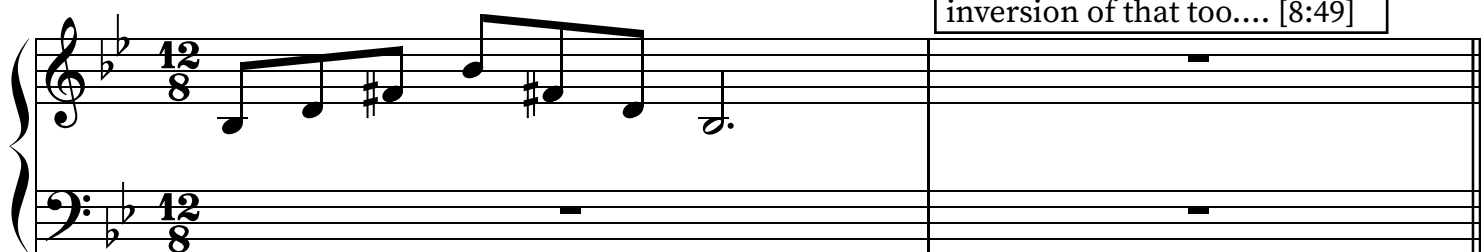


You know, on A flat major, that's an A flat major triad but inverting. [8:20]

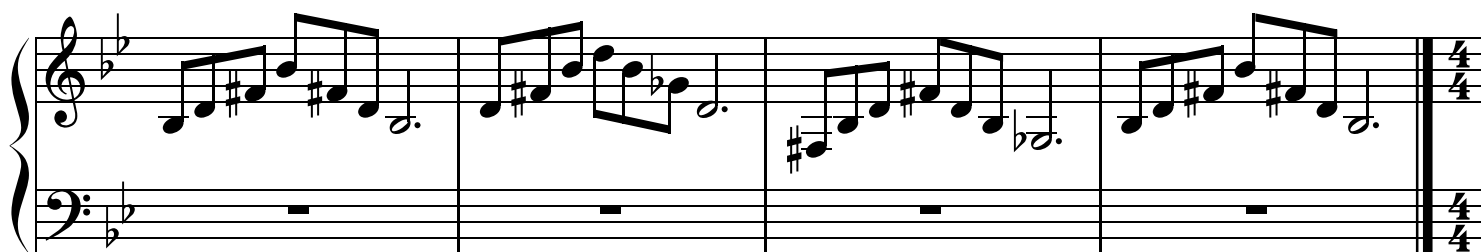
So, Bird [Charlie Parker] knew that. Then we have to practice that too.

There's another really pretty arpeggio that comes in tunes. It's the augmented arpeggio. So, the difference between a major arpeggio and an augmented arpeggio is you just sharp the fifth. So an augmented arpeggio looks like that... [8:43]

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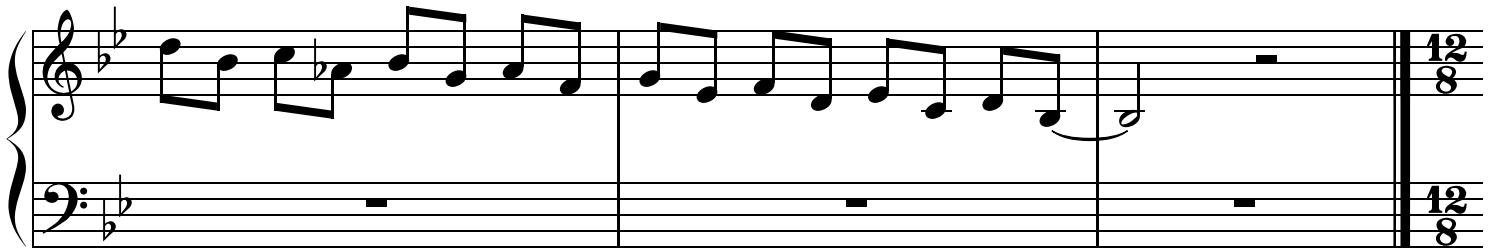
[7:56] Why practice that? Well, to put it in the context there's a Charlie Parker blues head "Chi Chi" that uses an inversion of the major triad. And it starts like this.... [8:10]

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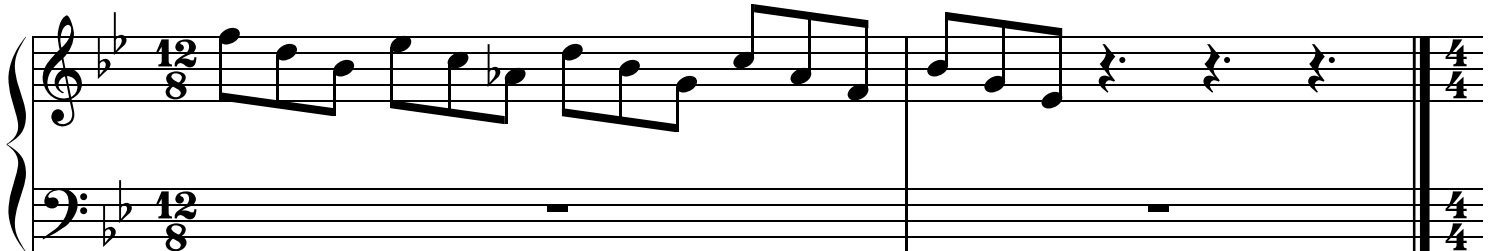
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Why not going down... [9:45]



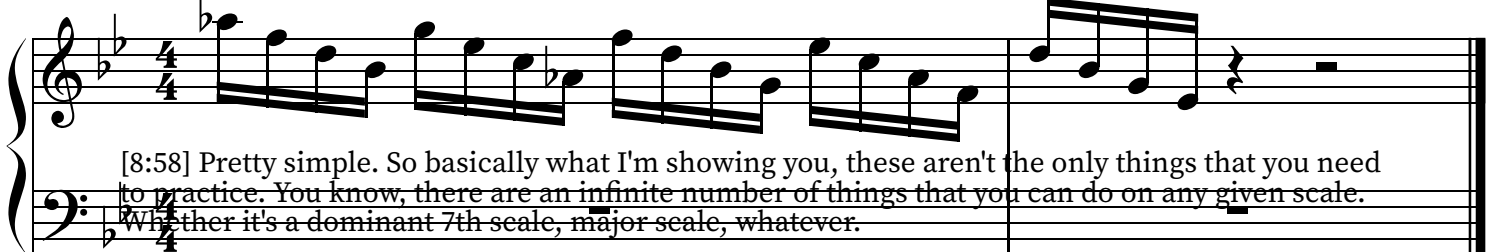
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Or, what about triads going down? [9:52]



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Or the full seventh chord...



[8:58] Pretty simple. So basically what I'm showing you, these aren't the only things that you need to practice. You know, there are an infinite number of things that you can do on any given scale. Whether it's a dominant 7th scale, major scale, whatever.

It's just up to you to explore those different options, so that you have more,...you have more puzzle pieces to work with in order to put them together to make phrases, right?

[9:28] Let's see what else I can think of. There's also.... And anything that you can do ascending, you can also do descending. So at the beginning when I did thirds going up.....

Right? So there so much that you can explore with this.

Now, let's talk about, let's go back to the fully diminished seventh chord for a second. You know after watching previous videos....

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B $\flat$ dim⁷ 3

B $\flat$ ⁷

that the dominant 7 comes from a fully diminished 7th chord

[10:20] Right? So that automatically means if I'm soloing over a chord that has, that's dominant in quality I can use a fully diminished seventh chord... [10:33]

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[10:40] It's perfectly valid because that's where a dominant seventh comes from.

So, I just wanted to give you a few ideas of things to practice over a dominant 7th scale. And in the next video I'm going to talk about something that will really help your agility and ability to move quickly between different ideas in an effective way that makes strong resolutions. And will ultimately make your improvisation sound more intelligent. So stay tuned for the next video. I've got a good one coming for you.